Little Acorns Early Learning

Family Handbook 2026

Austin, Texas · Durham, North Carolina · Portland, Oregon

Little Acorns Early Learning is a nonprofit organization. This handbook applies to all of our centers.

This is a fictional handbook created to demonstrate CareRules. Any resemblance to a real program is coincidental.

Welcome

Welcome to Little Acorns! We are a nonprofit early learning program serving children from 6 weeks through 5 years old, with after-school care for children up to age 12 at our Austin location. We believe children learn best through play, relationships and a safe, predictable day. This handbook explains how our centers work and what you can expect from us. Please read it, keep it handy, and sign the acknowledgment on the last page.

Hours and Closings

Our centers are open Monday through Friday, 7:00 a.m. to 6:00 p.m., all year except for the following holidays: New Year's Day, Memorial Day, Independence Day, Labor Day, Thanksgiving Day and the day after, Christmas Eve and Christmas Day. We also close for two staff training days each year, announced at least 30 days in advance.

If we must close because of severe weather, we will send a message through our parent app and post on our website by 6:00 a.m.

Enrollment

To enroll, families complete our registration form, the enrollment agreement, an emergency contact and authorized pickup form, and the child's health and immunization record. Enrollment is complete once all forms are received and the registration fee is paid. We admit children without regard to race, religion, national origin, sex or disability, and we make reasonable accommodations for children with special needs.

Health Screenings

Depending on your child's age, state rules may require proof of vision and hearing screening at enrollment. We'll tell you which screenings apply and help you find free screening events if you need them.

Insurance

Little Acorns carries general liability insurance at each of our centers. A certificate of insurance is available from the director on request.

Tuition and Fees

Tuition is billed monthly and is due on the 1st of each month through autopay. A late fee of $25 applies to payments received after the 5th. Tuition is not reduced for absences, holidays or closings. We accept child care subsidy, and families receiving subsidy pay only their assigned parent fee. Please give us two weeks' written notice before withdrawing your child.

Arrival and Pickup

Please walk your child into the classroom and sign them in on the tablet at the front desk. A staff member must greet your child before you leave.

We release children only to parents and to adults listed on the child's authorized pickup form. We will ask for photo ID from anyone we don't recognize. If someone not on the list needs to pick up your child, please call the director in advance and add them in writing. We will not release a child to an adult who appears to be impaired; in that case we will call the other parent or an emergency contact.

Late pickup. If you are running late, please call us. A late pickup fee of $1 per minute applies after 6:00 p.m. If a child has not been picked up by 6:30 p.m. and we cannot reach any parent or emergency contact, we will contact local law enforcement.

Classrooms and Staffing

Children are grouped by age. We keep classes small so every child gets attention:

Classroom	Ages	Teachers to children	Largest class
Seedlings	6 weeks – 12 months	1 to 4	8
Sprouts	1 – 2 years	1 to 6	12
Saplings	3 years	1 to 12	18
Acorns (Pre-K)	4 years	1 to 20	24
Oaks (after school, Austin)	5 – 12 years	1 to 22	30

All lead teachers are at least 18 years old, and every staff member completes a background check before working with children.

A Day at Little Acorns

Each day includes indoor and outdoor play, circle time, small-group activities, meals and rest. Children play outside at least twice a day unless the weather is dangerous. Screen time is limited to occasional educational programs.

Physical activity. Active play helps children grow strong, sleep well and learn. Every day, children have time for running, climbing, dancing and ball games, both outdoors on our playground and indoors in our movement room when the weather keeps us in. Teachers lead at least two short active games each day and join in the play.

Sunscreen and insect repellent. With your written permission, we apply the sunscreen you provide before outdoor play, and insect repellent when needed. Products must be labeled with your child's name. We don't apply sunscreen or repellent to babies under 6 months.

Water play and animals. We don't offer swimming or wading pools. Children may play at a water table with a teacher present. We don't keep classroom pets; if a visitor brings an animal, we tell families in advance.

Rest and Safe Sleep

Children 12 months and older rest on individual cots after lunch for up to two hours. Children who don't sleep may read quietly.

Infants sleep in individual cribs, following their own schedules. Babies are placed on their backs to sleep, with no blankets, pillows or toys in the crib. To avoid waking a baby, infants who fall asleep in a bouncer, swing or car seat may finish their nap there as long as a teacher can see them.

Guidance and Discipline

We use positive guidance: clear expectations, redirection, praise and natural consequences. We never use spanking, shaking or any physical punishment, and we never shame or yell at children. When a child needs a break, a teacher may offer a short time-out in the classroom, about one minute per year of age, with the teacher nearby. Children who throw food or refuse to sit at lunch may lose their dessert for that day.

Meals and Allergies

We serve breakfast, lunch and an afternoon snack that meet USDA nutrition guidelines. The daily menu, including all meals and snacks, is posted at the entrance of each center. Please tell

us in writing about any food allergy. For children with a severe allergy, we need an allergy action plan signed by the child's health care provider before the child's first day.

Illness

To keep everyone healthy, please keep your child home if they have a fever of 100.4°F or higher, vomiting, diarrhea, an unexplained rash, or are too sick to take part in normal activities. If your child becomes ill at the center, we will call you and you must pick up within one hour. Children may return when they have been fever-free for 24 hours without medicine.

Medication

We can give prescription and over-the-counter medicine during the day when it is necessary. Medicine must be in its original container, labeled with your child's name. To make things easier for busy families, you may authorize medication by phone or by text message to your child's teacher, and we will note your permission in the medication log. We record every dose we give.

Injuries and Emergencies

Every classroom has a first aid kit. All teachers and the director hold current pediatric first aid certification, and at least one staff member with current pediatric CPR certification is at each center whenever children are present. If your child has a minor injury, we will tell you at pickup and give you a written incident report. For a serious injury we will call 911 first and then call you right away.

We practice a fire drill every month, and children learn to leave the building quickly and calmly. We also practice shelter-in-place and lockdown drills several times a year. Our evacuation map is posted in every classroom.

Field Trips

Older children sometimes walk to the park or library near the center. We'll let you know about walking trips on the morning of the trip. For trips by bus, we'll ask you to sign a permission slip.

Child Abuse and Neglect

We take children's safety very seriously. If a staff member suspects that a child has been abused or neglected, they tell the center director, who looks into the concern and decides whether to contact child protective services.

Records and Privacy

Your child's records are confidential and are shared only with you, our staff and licensing staff. We keep attendance and children's records for at least three years after a child leaves our program, or longer if state rules require it.

Communication and Visiting

Parents are welcome to visit at any time during our hours, without calling first. We share updates through our parent app and hold parent-teacher conferences twice a year.

Your rights as a parent. You have the right to visit your child at any time we are open, to see your child's records, to see our most recent licensing inspection report (posted at the entrance), and to contact the state licensing agency with any concern about our program. We will never take action against a family for raising a concern.

Questions and concerns. We want to hear from you. Please talk with your child's teacher first; if your concern isn't resolved, ask for a meeting with the center director, who will meet with you within three business days. You may also contact your state's child care licensing office at any time. The office's phone number is posted at the entrance.

Acknowledgment

I have received and read the Little Acorns Family Handbook and agree to follow its policies.

_____

Parent or guardian signature and date

_____

Child's name